

A Long Journey



SUMMARY

The speaker describes the passage of several decades under colonial rule, likening the steady flow of time to the flow of water. These years, the speaker says, were filled with suffering so consistent and so great that the pain was like a river's current. Surviving this time meant enduring harsh labor, beatings, and imprisonment. The journey through these years, the speaker says, has felt terribly long.

When cars arrived in the speaker's village, new technology begins to replace traditional farming practices. For a time, the speaker says, British bicycles were the only thing that the little boys in the villages wanted.

Buses arrived in the village as well, linking it up to the city, and the people of the village began to long for a new kind of life far from their home.

It was a long, long journey, the speaker says, from a rural life to an urban one.

Now the speaker feels haunted by memories of a long-ago way of life, far back before the year 1890, when British colonial rule started in Zimbabwe. The speaker feels that the new, more modern and peaceful life they are living in Zimbabwe's capital city is threatened by thoughts of this past. While the speaker struggles painfully to forget, they can't do it, and the thought of the pre-colonial past (with its dirt roads and weather-beaten huts) continues to trouble them.

In the process of transitioning to modern life in the capital city, the speaker and people like them have separated themselves from old superstitions and traditional beliefs in magic. But under the bright lights of the city, the speaker still feels as if they can hear echoes of old violence and dark spells.

Though the speaker feels they've moved into a new, more modern way of life, they can still feel (around the dark edges of the city) an ancient, immense power reaching out to grab them.

legacy as are the comforts of a more modern world.

The poem's speaker—a native Zimbabwean—describes a transition “from bush to concrete,” illustrating how colonialism literally reshapes the environment by paving roads, clearing forests, and erecting buildings. The speaker here is [alluding](#) to the industrialization of Zimbabwe under British colonial rule. The mention of “pick and shovel” highlights how Zimbabweans were the ones tasked with building this infrastructure, however. The mention of “sjambok,” or cattle-prod/riding crop, and “jail” further allude to the brutal oppression of Zimbabweans and how the British forced locals into compliance. Colonialism's legacy is, then, is linked with suffering and violence.

Indeed, the history of past colonial violence, as well as the possibility of the country returning to a similar violence in the present, lingers even after the British have left. The speaker appreciates living in “new-found luxury” but also says that they still hear “the cry from human blood / and wicked bones rattling around me.” These lines might acknowledge the suffering that went into the country's modernization. Given that this poem was written shortly after Zimbabwean independence, won after years of civil war, those “wicked bones” might also evoke the specific violence of the nation's fight to throw off its colonizers. In either interpretation, the spectral imagery nods to the idea that the memory of colonial horror still casts a pall over everyday life. It also reveals that the speaker's enjoyment of modern comforts and opportunities is tinged by guilt and perhaps even a sense of betrayal of their own people.

The speaker also says that their “road runs and turns into dusty gravel” and “a mud-grass dwelling / threatened by wind and rain and cold,” an image suggesting that this modern, postcolonial world is in fact not all that far removed from the hardship and poverty of the recent past. Even as the speaker and fellow Zimbabweans have “moved into the lights,” an “almighty hand” stretches out from the darkness and “reaches for our shirts.” This hints that the modern world is unstable or doesn't feel entirely solid to the speaker and that further violence or political unrest may threaten to pull the city back into chaos.



THEMES



THE COMPLICATED LEGACY OF COLONIALISM

Zimbabwean poet Musaemura Zimunya's “A Long Journey” describes the complex series of transformations that a village undergoes during British colonial rule. On the one hand, the poem suggests that colonial rule helped to usher in a better life for many. At the same time, the poem illustrates the immense suffering and violence colonialism created and hints that instability and unrest are as much a part of the colonial

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-30



THE COST OF DEVELOPMENT

“A Long Journey” explores the impact of industrialization on a rural village in Zimbabwe. While the speaker appreciates many of the comforts and conveniences of modern life, they also struggle with the fact

that such development distances them from their ancestral past. Development, the poem illustrates, often comes at the cost of culture and tradition.

The poem describes the transformation of the speaker's rural village over time, revealing how modernity can conflict with traditional ways of life. For example, the death of "the sledge and the ox-cart" [symbolizes](#) the death of the village's traditional farming and agricultural practices as new technologies make work more efficient.

Keeping with this idea, the speaker observes that the "bus" brought "the city [...] into the village." The bus connects rural and urban spaces, allowing those in the village to "yearn for the place behind the horizons"—that is, to long for a world different from and beyond the one their ancestors knew. The children—the future of the village—also want a piece of modernity: the speaker says that "for a while the bicycle made in Britain / was the dream of every village boy." The new products are temporarily attractive because they represent a newfound mobility and freedom to travel beyond the village.

The mention of the bicycle also illustrates how fading of tradition coincides with the introduction of new, British desires: industrialization causes a loss of identity as the village's youth adopt a different set of wants, and implicitly, values. The speaker, too, admits to liking the "new-found luxury" of his more urban life.

The comforts and possibilities of a modern world aren't free, however: the speaker regards modern development with desire as well as dread, sensing how this modern world is in continuous tension with the past. The speaker says, "now I am haunted by the cave dwelling / hidden behind eighteen ninety / threatening my new-found luxury." British colonial rule in Zimbabwe began in 1890; the line thus implies that the speaker feels disconnected from and even frightened of their pre-colonial past—of the pre-1890 world that existed before British colonialism drastically reshaped the country.

The speaker also notes that "We have fled from witches and wizards / on a long long road to the city," suggesting a desire to separate themselves from old superstitions and traditional beliefs. Yet the speaker can also "hear the cry from human blood / and wicked bones rattling around me," which seems to evoke the call of the very traditions left behind. The past isn't as eager to let go of the speaker as the speaker is to let go of the past.

The speaker situates all these feelings "in this the capital city of my mother country," emphasizing their deep connection to their homeland even while acknowledging how much it has changed. Ultimately, "A Long Journey" illustrates the continuous tension between that pre-colonial past and the modern world—and shows how such a tension affects people like the speaker who have ties to both worlds.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-30



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*Through decades that ...
... long long journey*

The first line of "A Long Journey" introduces "decades" of suffering through a pained [simile](#): these years, the speaker says, ran like "endless rivers of endless woes."

The "decades" in question, the poem will reveal, are the years between 1890 and 1980, when Britain colonized Zimbabwe, inflicting violence and injustice on the people who lived there. The speaker remembers this as a time of "pick and shovel sjambok and jail"—in other words, of abuse, cruelty, and imprisonment:

- "Pick and shovel" are the tools that Zimbabweans used in construction and land development when forced to work for British colonists—[metonyms](#) for that unwilling labor.
- A "sjambok," even more menacingly, is a heavy leather whip, often made from hippopotamus or rhinoceros hide. While the sjambok was first used by herdsmen for cattle driving, it was later employed by British colonial police forces as a weapon to beat Zimbabwean civilians. "Jail," meanwhile, speaks for itself.

These years of colonial violence, thank goodness, are over now. The speaker and their country have come out on the other side of that river of time, but only after a "long long journey." The intense [epizeuxis](#) on "long" there suggests that it's hard for the speaker to even begin to convey how endless that [metaphorical](#) "journey" to independence felt while it was happening. This will be a story of postcolonial struggle, one describing what Zimbabwe has gained and lost.

"A Long Journey" is written in [free verse](#), with no regular meter or [rhyme scheme](#). This speaker often doesn't even use punctuation where one normally might. (For instance, there's no comma between "pick and shovel" and "sjambok and jail.") The overall effect feels intimate and reflective: it's almost as if readers are listening in on the haunted speaker's thoughts of the past.

LINES 5-8

*When the motor-car ...
... every village boy*

The speaker now thinks back to the early years of British

colonialism in Zimbabwe. It was a time of violence, they recall—but also a time of modernization that brought new technologies to rural villages.

One such technology was the “motor-car.” When cars arrived, the speaker remembers, they quickly began to replace traditional agricultural vehicles like the “sledge” and the “ox-cart.” Both these rustic tools became obsolete once newer, more efficient technology was introduced. That, the speaker suggests, was true of many things. As modernity encroached upon the village, longstanding traditional ways of life were destroyed and replaced.

That might sound purely tragic. But there’s something playful and exciting going on here, too. Alongside the car, the colonizers brought “the bicycle made in Britain”—a toy that “every village boy” craved. New technology here feels *alluring* as well as invasive. Or at least, “for a while.” Eventually, the speaker hints, those bicycles won’t seem so exotic and exciting to the village boys: they’ll become familiar, just another part of the changed landscape.

The bicycle and car here [symbolize](#) a change in values and beliefs: colonial industrialization causes a loss of traditional Zimbabwean identity. Not only do the old physical practices of the past (sledge, ox-cart) begin to die, but colonialism begins to phase out the traditional aspirations and desires of the villagers as well.

Readers might notice here that the new technologies the speaker describes are all to do with movement: cars and bikes get you from one place to another. These new vehicles, then, kick off a stage in the country’s [metaphorical](#) “long long journey.”

LINES 9-11

*With the arrival ...
... behind the horizons*

As Zimbabwe’s villages modernized, the speaker remembers, the world of the city got linked up to the world of the village. Like the “motor-car” and the British bicycles in the previous stanza, the “arrival of the bus” in line 9 marks another transformation in the village’s and the speaker’s history.

In the previous stanza, outside technology and products were brought to the village and integrated into village life (new bicycles, the motor-car replacing the sledge and ox-cart). The bus, even more significantly, *connects* rural and urban spaces, not only making it possible for the villagers to physically travel to the city, but [symbolizing](#) modernity further encroaching into traditional life. Two different parts of the country—and two different lifestyles—begin to merge into one as industrialization continues.

The bus and the connection it creates also allows those in the village to “yearn for the place behind the horizons”—that is, to long for a world beyond the one their ancestors knew. Now

that the speaker and their fellow villagers have not only seen products from the modern world, but also have the means to travel to that other world, their aspirations and desires begin to change. The bus allows wistful “yearn[ings]” about a different kind of life to become a reality for the villagers.

LINES 12-13

*Such a long ...
... bush to concrete*

The poem now introduces a sudden short stanza, just two lines long. Here, it feels as if the speaker is pausing to reflect, shaking their head over all the changes they’ve just described.

Listen to their [repetitions](#):

Such a long travail it was
a long journey from bush to concrete

That [parallelism](#) (and the [diacope](#) on “long”) stresses the difficulty of both a literal and a [metaphorical](#) journey. On the literal level, it’s a serious trek to get from the rural village to the city. Metaphorically, though, this is a vision of how hard it was to get from “bush to concrete” ([metonyms](#) for traditional vs. modern ways of life) *internally*. In other words, there’s a vast difference between how Zimbabweans once lived and how they live now.

The use of the word “travail” here (meaning a strenuous ordeal) also suggests that this has been a *painful* journey. Readers might here look back at the first stanza’s [allusions](#) to “pick and shovel sjambok and jail” with a shiver. Colonialism didn’t just come in and change things in Zimbabwe, it changed them through cruelty and oppression.

This passage might also evoke the way that colonialism literally reshapes the environment: by paving roads, clearing forest, and erecting buildings. The industrialization of Zimbabwe under British colonial rule didn’t just change people, it changed the landscape.

LINES 14-17

*And now I ...
... my mother country*

In lines 14-17, the speaker shifts from reminiscing about the past to describing their current fears and anxieties. These days, the speaker says, they live in “new-found luxury” in the “capital city of [their] mother country”: that is, they’ve decisively left rural life behind and moved to Harare, the capital of Zimbabwe. The turn of phrase “my mother country” emphasizes the speaker’s deep connection to their homeland.

But beneath this glamorous, modern new life, they still feel haunted by the past. They feel the presence of the ancient “cave dwelling”—a way of life even more rustic than the one they once knew—“hidden” way back “behind eighteen ninety.” In

other words, they still feel the ghostly presence of a way of Zimbabwean life dating back to before 1890, when the British first colonized Zimbabwe (then referred to as "Rhodesia").

The line implies that the speaker feels disconnected from and even a little frightened of their pre-colonial past—and that they can't escape it. The memory of a time they never saw threatens the stability and comfort of the speaker's present-day "new-found luxury." The past doesn't vanish so easily, these lines suggest; the speaker here feels the continuing presence of a kind of life they themselves never led, the most ancient of ways.

While "A Long Journey" doesn't use much rhyme, Zimunya does incorporate some [slant rhyme](#) in this passage. Though there are no true end rhymes in the poem, the sounds of "ninety," "luxury," and "country" in lines 15-17 do create a chime. This continuation of similar—but not identical—sounds in this section perhaps nods to the idea of the past persisting: sound fragments from the year "eighteen ninety" become embedded in the word "country" itself just a couple of lines later.

LINES 18-22

*I fight in ...
... rain and cold*

Lines 18-22 deepen the speaker's picture of ancestral Zimbabwean memory. "Haunted" by Zimbabwe's long-ago pre-colonial past, the speaker feels as if they're in a "nightmar[e]," struggling to escape visions of what once was.

No matter how they try to escape, they say, they feel their "road [...] turn[ing] into dusty gravel," then into "over-beaten foot tracks," carrying them "to a plastic hut and soon to a mud-grass dwelling." This image of [metaphorically](#) journeying deeper and deeper into the past—moving from gravel paths to mud ones, plastic huts to mud ones—suggests that, whether they like it or not, the speaker feels a deep involuntary connection to what Zimbabwe once was, long before the British came.

These aren't sentimental memories. The speaker feels keenly aware that the long-ago "mud-grass dwelling[s]" were perpetually "threatened by wind and rain and cold"; in their life of "new-found luxury" in the city, that part of the pre-colonial past doesn't sound so great.

But these memories also bring a sense of continuity and connection, linking the speaker to a world that their whole country has made a "long long journey" away from. The speaker's modern present is in continuous tension with the past.

LINES 23-27

*We have fled ...
... rattling around me*

Lines 23 and 24 further develop the tension between the speaker's modern, urban life and the rural, pre-colonial past. The speaker says that they and their countrypeople have fled

from "witches and wizards"—that is, from traditional beliefs. The "long long road to the city" has carried them away from magic. Once again, the "long long road" here is part of the poem's overarching [extended metaphor](#): it's not only the literal dirt paths and paved roads that make up the route from the village to the city, but the long time the speaker (and Zimbabwe as a whole) have spent trying to separate themselves from their past.

The speaker's image of escaping from "witches and wizards" on the way to the city suggests that attaining the comforts of modern life in the city has come at a cost; Zimbabwe has lost not just a physical but a spiritual way of life. Looking back at those ancient beliefs, the speaker seems as ambivalent as they were about the "mud-grass dwelling / threatened by wind and rain and cold." The witches and wizards seem to scare them; they *want* to flee from these ancestral figures, they feel pursued.

But again, they can't really escape. Beyond the "halo of tower lights"—the glow of tall buildings in modern Harare—they still "hear the cry from human blood / and wicked bones rattling around me." These images might be seen as echoes of the ancient religious rituals those "witches and wizards" practiced, with bone rattles and blood sacrifices.

However, these gory images might also [allude](#) to the Zimbabweans brutalized by the British, their wounded bodies calling out for revenge—or just for acknowledgment of the suffering that went into the construction of the city's "newfound luxury." The past, in other words, surrounds the speaker no matter what, and it calls out to them like a ghost.

In the past two stanzas, readers might observe, the poem's themes seem to have reversed. In stanzas 1-4, modernity, colonialism, and industrialization encroach on the world of the village. In stanzas 5-6, images and figures associated with the past encroach upon the modern city, threatening to enter and transform it.

LINES 28-30

*We moved into ...
... for our shirts*

The final stanza escalates the tension between the modern present and the pre-colonial past.

"We moved into the lights," the speaker says, suggesting that Zimbabwe has moved further into the embrace of modernity and urban life. The lights, here, [symbolize](#) the comforts and new beliefs of the post-colonial world. But there's a "dark periphery" around that electric glow. The past, as the speaker has vividly suggested, is never very far away, no matter how long a journey one takes to escape it. And in Zimbabwe's case, that past involves both a lot of terrible suffering and a lot of lost tradition and culture.

Beyond the "halo of tower lights," the speaker says, an

"almighty hand" lurks, threatening to reach through the light's protective barrier, grab the speaker and their fellow citizens by their "shirts," and yank them back into their memories—painful and melancholy, horrific and wistful. That strange, disembodied hand [metaphorically](#) suggests the sheer power of the past, and perhaps even hints at something even bigger: a god-like force that demands history be reckoned with.

These images suggest that this modern, post-colonial Zimbabwe is not all that far removed from the hardship and poverty of the recent past. To this poem's speaker, the modern world feels fragile and endangered, and there's no way to live there comfortably without a deep (and perhaps impossible) denial of the years that lie "behind" the present. Zimbabwe's past continues to cast a shadow over everyday life.



SYMBOLS



CITY LIGHTS

The electric lights that shine from building windows and streetlights in this poem's capital city [symbolize](#) industrialization and modernity. Just as the lights illuminate the city at night, the development of the country reveals new paths forward following independence. These lights, then, suggests Zimbabwe's advancement toward a more modern, technological way of life.

But that change isn't fully a good thing, and it isn't total. The "halo" of electric light here stands in contrast to the "dark periphery"—the darkness of the rural, colonial past, which still haunts the speaker. The "almighty hand" of history, the speaker feels, always threatens to reach out from that darkness and snatch them away from the bright lights of their new life.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 25:** "the halo of," "tower lights"
- **Line 28:** "We moved into the lights"



POETIC DEVICES

SIMILE

Zimunya uses a [simile](#) to compare decades of Zimbabwean suffering to the length and continuous flow of a river. Zimunya chooses the river as a simile because of rivers' length, winding paths, and constant motion—all also features of Zimbabwe's "endless woes."

But the image of the river is also connected to the poem's overarching [metaphor](#) of the "long journey" away from those woes—a journey that can't actually take the speaker (or Zimbabwe) out of reach of the past. In the same way that a river

carries water from a faraway source, Zimbabwe's suffering stretches and zigzags across time and history. The painful experiences of the past move through history in the same way that a river might move through a landscape. Though the speaker is a modern person living in a modern city, they still feel haunted by the "endless woes" of colonial times.

Crossing a river can also [symbolize](#) overcoming a difficulty or entering a new era. Though, as the speaker says, Zimbabwe has moved on both from colonialism and from its rural past, the idea that the immense tragedies of the past have shaped the Zimbabwean people (and still affect them in the present) remains a key concept in the poem.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "decades that ran like rivers / endless rivers of endless woes"

ALLITERATION

[Alliteration](#) intensifies moments in the poem. For example, the rough, guttural /r/ sounds of "ran like rivers" and "road runs" (lines 1 and 19) help to highlight the length and difficulty of the journey the speaker is describing. Similarly, in line 5, the crisp /c/ sounds of "motor-car came" and "ox-cart" add a sharp bite to the speaker's description of modernity encroaching onto village life. (Note that there's also [consonance](#) here in the growling /r/ sounds in "motor-car" and "cart").

The alliteration in lines 7-8 rings out particularly clearly:

[...] the **b**icycle made in **B**ritain
was the dream of every village **b**oy

These bold sounds link the bicycle to its place of origin, emphasizing the fact that, to the children of the speaker's village, the bike is an exciting, exotic object. The sounds also simply call readers' attention to the "dream of every village boy."

Likewise, the alliteration of "capital"/"country," "witches"/"wizards," and "blood"/"bones" helps to highlight the speaker's connection to this country as well as the violence and terror of the past.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "ran," "rivers"
- **Line 3:** "jail"
- **Line 4:** "journey"
- **Line 5:** "car came"
- **Line 6:** "cart"
- **Line 7:** "but," "bicycle," "Britain"
- **Line 8:** "boy"
- **Line 17:** "capital," "country"

- **Line 19:** "road runs"
- **Line 23:** "witches," "wizards"
- **Line 26:** "blood"
- **Line 27:** "bones"

REPETITION

Throughout "A Long Journey," Zimunya uses [repetitions](#) to emphasize the length of the speaker's history and the exhausting struggles that the speaker and their community have lived through.

For instance, in the first two lines, the speaker doubles the words "rivers" and "endless":

Through decades that ran like **rivers**
endless rivers of **endless** woes

The [diacope](#) here stresses just how long and painful the years of British colonial oppression felt to the Zimbabwean people.

In line 3, meanwhile, the speaker uses [parallelism](#) to capture those people's constant sufferings under colonialism. These years, they say, were a time of "pick and shovel sjambok and jail"—a phrasing that feels as relentless as the labor, pain, and injustice these words evoke (and even more so because the speaker omits the comma that might usually fall between "shovel" and "sjambok").

Later on in line 22, [polysyndeton](#) creates a similar intensifying effect. When the speaker remembers the long-ago Zimbabwean "mud-grass dwelling[s]" that were "threatened by wind and rain and cold," those repeated "ands" suggest that it was just one thing after another back then: cruel weather stacks up and compounds.

But perhaps the most striking repetition in the poem is the one that echoes the poem's title over and over again. In line 4, the speaker cries, "O such a **long long journey**" (and note the emphatic epizeuxis on "long" there); in line 12, there's a "**long travail**" immediately followed by another "**long journey**" in line 13; finally, there's a "**long long road**" in line 24. These repetitions help to communicate the emotional effect of a long, exhausting struggle. Just as the poem narratively follows a long journey (both literal and [metaphorical](#)), so too does the actual word "journey" travel throughout the poem.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "rivers"
- **Line 2:** "endless rivers of endless woes"
- **Line 3:** "pick and shovel sjambok and jail"
- **Line 4:** "long long"
- **Line 12:** "long travail"
- **Line 13:** "long journey"

- **Line 22:** "wind and rain and cold"
- **Line 24:** "long long road"

EXTENDED METAPHOR

Zimunya uses the [extended metaphor](#) of the "journey" to depict the speaker's experience of leaving a traditional culture behind for a modern one—and to suggest that, no matter how far the speaker appears to have traveled from their past, it's still right there with them.

The metaphor of the "long journey" compares the exhaustion and distance of a long walk to the many struggles the speaker (and Zimbabwe) have had to navigate. The speaker follows this road of experiences from a rural, traditional life in their village to an urban, modern life in the city; Zimbabwe, too, follows this trajectory, transforming from a rural to an urban society under British colonial rule. The country's "long journey" carries it through and past colonial oppression.

While this journey seems linear in the first four stanzas, the speaker also feels that the metaphorical road they travel might loop back to a painful past at any moment. In line 19, they observe that "my road runs and turns into dusty gravel." This image highlights the idea that Zimbabwe's rural, traditional past is never really that far away from the speaker; their internal "road" often turns back toward their history. Though they (and the country) have in many ways journeyed far from their origins, there's no escaping the past.

Where Extended Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 4:** "O such a long long journey"
- **Line 13:** "a long journey from bush to concrete"
- **Lines 19-22:** "but my road runs and turns into dusty gravel / into over-beaten foot tracks that lead / to a plastic hut and soon to a mud-grass dwelling / threatened by wind and rain and cold"
- **Lines 28-30:** "We moved into the lights / but from the dark periphery behind / an almighty hand reaches for our shirts."

ALLUSION

Throughout "A Long Journey," Zimunya [alludes](#) to Zimbabwean history—and particularly the country's painful history of colonial oppression under British rule.

In line 15, the speaker recalls the "cave dwelling / hidden behind eighteen ninety." Here, they're thinking of distant history: a time before 1890, when British colonialism first began in Zimbabwe.

These aren't the speaker's own memories. They live in the "new-found luxury" of the "capital city" of their "mother country": that is, Harare, a modern city, lit by a "halo of tower lights." The speaker's references to an ancient "cave dwelling,"

then, suggest that they're haunted by an ancestral Zimbabwean past, by collective memories that go back way further than their own lifetime. These lines even hint that Zimbabwe *itself* still mysteriously remembers how life was before the British arrived. Further allusions to Zimbabwe's rural past—to the "sledge and the ox-cart" with which Zimbabweans once farmed, to the "plastic hut[s]" and "mud-grass dwelling[s]" in which people once lived—make a similar point.

But perhaps the darkest allusions here touch on how that rural past disappeared. When the speaker describes years of "pick and shovel sjambok and jail," they're referring to the forced labor, beatings (with a "sjambok," a whip made of tough hide), and imprisonment through which British colonial forces oppressed and transformed Zimbabwe.

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** "through pick and shovel sjambok and jail"
- **Line 6:** "the sledge and the ox-cart began to die"
- **Line 15:** "eighteen ninety"
- **Lines 16-17:** "new-found luxury / in this the capital city of my mother country"
- **Lines 19-22:** "dusty gravel / into over-beaten foot tracks that lead / to a plastic hut and soon to a mud-grass dwelling / threatened by wind and rain and cold"
- **Line 23:** "witches and wizards"
- **Lines 26-27:** "I hear the cry from human blood / and wicked bones rattling around me"

Periphery (Line 29) - Edges, outskirts.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"A Long Journey" is written in [free verse](#). In other words, it doesn't use a traditional form (like the [sonnet](#) or [villanelle](#)), a regular [meter](#), or a [rhyme scheme](#). The poem's thirty lines are divided into seven stanzas of all different lengths; the shortest is only two lines long, the longest nine.

Zimunya shapes these flexible stanzas to match the progression of the poem's story. For example, the first four short stanzas follow Zimbabwe's movement from "bush to concrete," rural to urban life (by way of dire colonial cruelty). Then comes the fifth stanza: nine lines of agony in which the speaker reflects that, though they're happy enough in the "new-found luxury" of city life, they feel continually haunted by thoughts of the village life they came from (and by dark memories of violence and suffering). The movement into that surprising long stanza marks an emotional turning point.

METER

"A Long Journey" is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't use a regular meter. Zimunya freely varies the length and rhythm of his lines for effect.

For instance, listen to the way the third stanza builds:

With the arrival of the bus
the city was brought into the village
and we began to yearn for the place behind the
horizons

The rhythms of this passage mirror what the poem describes: as the villagers look out further and further "behind the horizons," the lines get longer and longer.

RHYME SCHEME

"A Long Journey" doesn't use a [rhyme scheme](#). The lack of rhyme here helps the speaker's voice to feel unstudied and reflective—almost as if readers are listening in on the speaker's thoughts.

While there are no true end rhymes in the poem, Zimunya does create a short series of [slant rhymes](#) in lines 15-17: "ninety," "luxury," and "country," all in a row. That subtle effect might tune in with the idea of Zimbabwe's past persisting into its present.



SPEAKER

The speaker in "A Long Journey" is a resident of Zimbabwe. While they have experienced life in a rural village and lived



VOCABULARY

Sjambok (Line 3) - A heavy leather whip, often made from hippopotamus or rhinoceros hide. While first used by herdsman for cattle driving, the sjambok was later used by British colonial police forces as a weapon against Zimbabwean civilians.

Sledge (Line 6) - A wheelless wooden cart used to transport wood, crops, or other materials. Here, the speaker mentions the sledge as one of the agricultural tools that became obsolete once newer, more efficient technology was introduced.

Yearn (Line 11) - To long for something.

Travail (Line 12) - A painful, laborious, and exhausting experience.

Bush (Line 13) - An area of densely overgrown wilderness.

Eighteen ninety (Line 15) - The year 1890, when British colonist first colonized Zimbabwe (then referred to as "Rhodesia").

Over-beaten foot tracks (Line 20) - That is, paths used so often that they're worn down to bare dirt.

through British colonial rule as well as the country's independence, they have since moved to the capital city, Harare. While the speaker appreciates and enjoys many of the comforts and conveniences of modern urban life, they also struggle with the fact that this new way of being distances them from their ancestral past.

The speaker remembers the decades of hard labor, violence, and imprisonment that British colonizers inflicted on Zimbabwe, and laments the loss of the traditional farming techniques [symbolized](#) by "the sledge and the ox-cart." But they also recognize the charms of the technological refinements that arrived with colonialism.

As the speaker shifts from reminiscing to reckoning with their present-day circumstances, they feel guilty for enjoying the "new-found luxury" of the city, knowing how much suffering and strife went into constructing that luxury. While the speaker tries to distance themselves from painful memories of their colonial past, they can't help but feel that a confrontation with their history is ominously encroaching.

Readers might easily imagine that Musaemura Zimunya himself is the speaker: he was born in British-occupied Zimbabwe (then known as Rhodesia) in 1949, lived through British colonialism, and moved to Harare in 1980.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Musaemura Zimunya (1949-present) included "A Long Journey" in his 1985 book *Country Dawns and City Lights*. The poems in the collection examine ideas of home, rural vs. urban landscapes, and the contrast between traditional and modern societies. Zimunya's previous poetry collections, *Thought Tracks* and *Kingfisher, Jikinya, and Other Poems* (each published in 1982) discuss similar themes.

Zimunya was expelled from the University of Rhodesia in 1973, when Zimbabwe was still under British rule. He completed his undergraduate and Master's degrees while exiled in Great Britain. When Zimbabwe achieved independence from Britain in 1980, he returned to his newly free country and worked there as an English professor. In 1999, he left Zimbabwe for the U.S. to take up a position as Director of Black Studies at Virginia Tech.

Zimunya's poetry—with its anxiety for the future and reflections on the lasting, aftershock-like effects of the past on the present—is often rooted in the years of Zimbabwe's early independence from Britain. Zimunya's concerns about spirituality, kinship, urban-rural dynamics, and fraying yet unbroken connections to home are also apparent in the work of other Zimbabwean writers publishing in the 1970s and 80s, like Chenjerai Hove and Charles Mungoshi.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

"A Long Journey" charts the long, sad history of British colonialism in Zimbabwe. Britain's grip on the country began in 1890, when the first British colonists set out to Zimbabwe from Botswana. Perhaps the most notorious of these colonists was Cecil Rhodes, a diamond magnate who took control over much of the territory; Zimbabwe was known as "Rhodesia" for some time. British colonists deprived native Zimbabweans of their rights over the country's resources (including gold, silver, and tobacco) and installed racist governments that made Zimbabweans second-class citizens in their own land.

By the late 1950s, resistance from native Zimbabweans (including Zimunya's own Shona people) grew: a number of African liberation political parties formed (though they were each swiftly banned by the British). Throughout the 1970s, continued resistance from the Zimbabwe African National Union, alongside increased diplomatic pressures from other countries, pushed Zimbabwe closer to independence. Transitional elections were eventually held in the late 1970s, and in the spring of 1980, Zimbabwe achieved independence from Britain. But as this poem documents, the repercussions of colonialism didn't end when British governance did.



SETTING

"A Long Journey" is set in Zimbabwe—or, perhaps, several different Zimbabwes. The poem [juxtaposes](#) village life in rural Zimbabwe during British occupation, life *before* British occupation, and life *after* British occupation in modern-day Harare (Zimbabwe's capital city).

The village uses traditional, wooden, animal-drawn tools like "the sledge and the ox-cart," and is surrounded by vast undeveloped stretches of "bush." The huts and the "dusty gravel" roads of the village stand in stark contrast to developed, industrialized Harare: where the village has "mud-grass dwelling[s]," Harare has tall "concrete" buildings blazing with "tower lights." Besides these comparisons, the speaker also feels haunted by Zimbabwe's truly ancient past, a time long before the British arrived when "cave dwelling[s]" were people's only homes.

The contrast of these details—a traditional, rural landscape (and sometimes a primeval one) followed by a modern, industrialized city—not only highlights the tension between the past and present, but the way the suffering and harsh living conditions of the rural past have transformed into the "new-found luxury" of the present.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [Zimbabwe's History](https://www.britannica.com/place/Zimbabwe/2008-elections-and-aftermath) — Read a brief history of Zimbabwe via the Encyclopedia Britannica. (<https://www.britannica.com/place/Zimbabwe/2008-elections-and-aftermath>)
- [Zimunya Sings](https://youtu.be/S4T3Cg2Ex90?si=YyQfAf3fvC6Xha4V) — Watch a video of Zimunya performing. (<https://youtu.be/S4T3Cg2Ex90?si=YyQfAf3fvC6Xha4V>)
- [A Brief Biography](https://www.poetryinternational.com/en/poets-poems/poets/poet/102-5760_Zimunya) — Learn more about Zimunya's life and work. (https://www.poetryinternational.com/en/poets-poems/poets/poet/102-5760_Zimunya)



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